The Child-Martyr

By Joyce Carol Oates

Not white-faced, exactly, but sour-cream-colored, a vicious color, so that his eyes-heavily outlined in black-and his insipid mouth -- salmon-rosy -- were exaggerated. The contortions of the mouth were exaggerated too. It must have been a mistake, but the parted lips revealed no teeth, only that absurd leadish black.

In glassy perfection, around him, were an aquatic blue and rosy-beige and a yellow too sullen with browns to represent sunshine, and of course a repetition of the unearthly white of his face. And the black. In the usual winter drizzle all colors looked sullen. But when the Ideal slipped into position behind the Real all went vivid, and for an instant his original martyrdom was evoked in that thrill of ecstatic pain: only the too-thick black panels between the pieces of glass reminded one of earth, of weighty metals.

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INTRODUCTION

The Orthodox Church is filled with accounts of courageous Christians who, throughout the ages, have witnessed their faith—not only in word but, most memorably, in deed. There are accounts of the "Child Martyrs" who take our breath away. We are humbled by these tiny ones who possessed more courage and conviction than most of us are able to relate to. Enter the silence of a Roman Catholic church with me. Surrounding us are the intricate stained-glass depictions of a variety of saints. The one that draws the most attention is that of The Child-Martyr – Can you imagine his thoughts; his perceptions in the stillness. Listen closely and you can almost hear him speak. The Child-Martyr by Joyce Carol Oates.

In the melodrama of an audience's pity (a small audience-usually women, usually old women) the grimace tightened; the slits of eyes seemed to shriek. It had been a habit, a long habit. It must have been a dream in the mind of whoever had put the window together. . . . One morning, however, the Child-Martyr allowed the grimace to twitch only on the right side of his mouth, the left remaining frozen. Did anyone notice. . . ? And one day he allowed the lips' natural desire to scream in

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church an inch or two of freedom, only two-dimensional, only visual: a nasty grin.

No more than three feet high, the Child-Martyr enjoyed a certain magnification because of an accident in the structure of the building. Located near the back pews, his window faced out on pavement; some of the other windows had become shaded, over the years, by oaks. So he enjoyed more sunshine. And the odor of damp and piety aided him because a child was out of place in this setting, one's sympathies were evoked at once. . . it was like discovering the skeleton of a kitten in an old cellar, with an earthen floor.

Though it was clear from the very first that the Child-Martyr was shifting inside the brute lead outlines, no one dared notice. There was a tradition of tear droplets, a tradition of stigmata, bloodstains and streaks exactly the color of real blood and drying even to the color of real blood. But the Child-Martyr was too young for tradition, or too stunted in his growth-his legs had been hurriedly and clumsily fashioned, tucked out of sight-for this alone he would never forgive the artisan

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who had pieced him together! He was poised up there, as if ready to spring. Fully awake and yet pretending to be asleep, but not with the grace of a respectful pretense, with a deliberately coarse pretense. . . an insult to his worshipers.

Of course they were not "his" alone; they rotated their worship from day to day, and on special private occasions, on occasions that involved tears and a mute terrible shaking of the head, they went to special windows, often to his. He did not mind sharing them. As time passed he longed to be less attractive, he did not at all mind the days no one prayed to him. . . . But it wasn't until he began to stare rudely at them through his black-edged eyes that he discovered a way of driving some away. Cunning, sly, furious in that sourish-white face, he discovered at the same time a centuries-old delight, slumbering in him.

Ah, the virginal dreamy stupidity of cold glass! He wanted music, he wanted more space. He began to murmur, to groan. A gutteral murmur back in the throat, a mockery of chaste agony. . . a mockery of the chastity

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that always stared up at him, out of others' eyes. Who are you worshiping. . . ? Is this only a mirror? -He sensed, from the immediate response, the cringing, the bewilderment, the fear, the tics -he sensed, in triumph, in a joy he had not felt since the original martyrdom, that he was correct in that diagnosis. All along he had been a mirror. And now he was coming alive to protest the stupidity of his makers, his worshipers, his importance, his amateurishly assorted features, his own ordeal. That ordeal had been pleasurable, but this, in glass, in the dank cellarish air, this was a lie. -A low gutteral moan. Bestial and intelligent. Groping to become audible. Inquisitive. Am I. . . ? Am I becoming one of you. . . ? Language instead of glass, music instead of mute babyish screams. . . ?

For centuries he, like the others on the side walls, stared slantwise to the altar. . . out of the corner of their souls they envied that position, the fullest whining triumphant martyrdom. . . in gold, in emeralds and diamonds and paste-pale exquisite flesh. . . a halo that shone without fear of being comic. Centuries of

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envy and silence. Now the Child-Martyr's low chuckle shattered those centuries. Someone was to write incoherently of him, scribbling down words as if to dispel the original chaos: Evidently before the assumption of one's role in his story, evidently before, evidently all the possibilities are in the seed (seeds?), evidently. . . yes but how to . . . how to unhook (unlock?) them without, with, without causing tidal waves and earthquakes, without. . . with full respect for one's ancestors and the Inquisition in the Marketplace. . .. But he ripped all this up. He prayed to the Child-Martyr to be delivered of his own madness. And yet again he found himself writing: ... before the beginning of history itself, before it, before it pieces the shards together. .. But what? What came before? What was it, where did it go, why is it lost, why is it now a nasty gap-mouthed grin? He ripped the pages up, prayed elsewhere with his rosary wrapped so tightly about his knuckles that the flesh showed the marks of the smooth black beads. Am I. . . ? Am I becoming human. . . ? Am I becoming God. . . ?

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God awakening in him made him childish and vicious and lopsided in his grinning-naturally he must mock, after such an eternity of fraudulent suffering! Whose fault is it, sneers the Child-Martyr, who invented all this martyrdom? Rolling his eyes back in his head he caught sight one day of the insipid halo floating three or four inches above him, in utter sky-blue virginity, and for an instant he wondered-with the terrible clarity of the child-if, all along, someone had been mocking him anyway. But the instant passed. No, too good to have been true! And the ironies accumulate, the insulting histrionic groans move toward language. -nearly audible?

He has a dread of the immediate future: of whispers that grow to exclamations and public prayers and public adorations, of a new excited worship of that old fraudulent martyrdom. Famous, must he become famous and martyred once again, so that no one will hear the sly innuendos in the moans, no one will smash the mirror and free him? Another possibility, which terrifies him even more, is that they will seize upon the parody and stumble away with it, stunned and giggling with it,

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and the original pain-so real, so exquisite!-will be totally lost. Still, he writhes into life. Evidently it is his fate.

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